CROOKED

LESS DOOM. MORE DOING.

Reference book: voice, tone, color, type, tokens, components and the concept collateral built from them.

Unofficial design exploration. Not affiliated with, endorsed by or connected to Crooked Media. Names, show art and marks belong to their owners. The wordmark is a typeset stand-in, not the official logo.

CONTENTS

WHAT'S INSIDE

01 **Overview**
The visual rules

02 **Voice and tone**
How it sounds

03 **Putting it into practice**
From brief to piece

04 **Midterm messaging**
Nov 2026 campaign layer

05 **Tokens**
Color, type, space, shape

06 **Components**
UI and collateral, with rules

07 **Concept collateral**
Posters, merch and hats from the rounds

OVERVIEW

Less doom. More doing. This system covers the Crooked homepage redesign concept and everything made from it: the site, posters, socials, the newsletter header, stickers and merch. It is an unofficial design exploration, not affiliated with or endorsed by Crooked Media. Show names, show art and marks belong to their owners. Every piece carries the `UnofficialMark`.

Read in this order: this page for the visual rules, **Voice and tone** for how it sounds, **Putting it into practice** for how a brief becomes a poster, a post or a product.

THE IDEA IN ONE LINE

Navy carries the brand, yellow does the work, and every piece ends with something to do: **Listen. Show up. Organize.** Keep that order whenever the three appear together.

COLOR

- Ground everything in `c-navy-900` (screens use `bg-inverse` for bands) or paper `bg-page`. Paper is blue-biased `c-slate-50`; never pure white for the page. White (`bg-surface`) is for cards and boxes sitting on paper.
- Use `accent-default` (yellow) for the one thing to click, the thing that's playing, focus and progress. If three things on screen are yellow, two of them are wrong.
- Use `status-live` (red 500) as a fill only: live pill, live dot, strike bars, calendar strips. For red text use `status-live-text` (red 700 light, red 300 dark).
- Put the player and nav on `bg-chrome` so tools read apart from editorial.
- Keep `con-*` sky, cream and butter inside Crooked Con placements. Two sanctioned exceptions in collateral: the climate poster sky and the "Hope is a verb" sticker.
- Pink `c-pink-300` is a collateral ground (reproductive freedom, stickers) with navy type. It never appears in product UI.
- Screen proportion: about 45 navy, 35 paper, 10 white, 7 yellow, 3 red.
- Collateral uses the `c-*` primitives directly because print and social art keep fixed colors in either theme. Product UI uses semantic tokens only (`bg-*`, `fg-*`, `border-*`, `accent-*`, `status-*`) so it follows light and dark.

Contrast, checked (WCAG 2.1)

PAIR	RATIO	RULE
`fg-default` on `bg-page`	15.3:1	Body and headings.
`fg-muted` on `bg-page`	5.5:1	Secondary text.

PAIR	RATIO	RULE
yellow on navy / navy on yellow	11.8:1	Display, links, CTAs, button labels.
`c-slate-300` on navy	8.6:1	Labels on navy.
navy on pink	10.1:1	Pink collateral.
cream on sky 700	4.9:1	Con headline, upper band only.
butter on sky 600	3.7:1	Display size only.
white on red 500	4.2:1	12px bold minimum in UI; display size in collateral.
red 700 on paper / on yellow	5.9:1 / 4.6:1	Red text.
butter or cream on sky 300	2.4–2.7:1	Fails. No type in the lower sky.
yellow on white	1.4:1	Never.

Focus: `focus-ring` (yellow) is 1.4:1 on white by itself, so every focus state pairs the 3px yellow outline with a 2px `fg-default` ring. Together they clear 3:1 on paper, white, navy and yellow.

TYPE

Three faces, three jobs. Never swap them.

- **Big Shoulders Display 900** for headlines and big numbers: `display-xl` hero, `display-l` section, `display-m` panel, `display-s` sub-head, `display-poster` for collateral. Caps by CSS, written in sentence case so they read right in feeds and screen readers. Leading `.92` on screen, `.86` in collateral.
- **Public Sans** for reading: `lede` 19px, `title` 16–20px bold, `body` 16px, `body-s` 14px, `button` 15px bold.
- **IBM Plex Mono 500** for metadata only: `eyebrow` 12px and `label-s` 11px, caps, tracking `f-track-label`. Show names, times, dates, counts. Tabular numerals for clocks, durations and prices.
- Nothing a person must read goes below 11px. Body copy and buttons are never in display caps. One eyebrow per block, only when it adds a fact.

LAYOUT, SPACE AND SHAPE

- The homepage reads like a rundown: today's lineup first, the player always in reach, one band for the ways to act. Order sections by what a listener does next, not by org chart.
- Max width `layout-max` (1240), gutter `layout-gutter` (16–48). Show grid 4 → 3 at 1000 → 2 at 720. Hero splits 1.25 : 1 and stacks at 860. Sections breathe `space-16` top and bottom.
- Spacing steps: `space-1` 4 through `space-16` 64. Card padding `space-6`; grid gaps `space-5`.
- `radius-pill` for every button, chip, tag and live pill. `radius-lg` (12) for art and cards, `radius-xl` (14) for lineup rows and the player, `radius-2xl` (16) for panels.
- Show art is always 1:1. Floating UI (previews, queues, checklists) gets a 2px `border-strong`.

- Depth: `shadow-card` on hovered cards over navy, `shadow-lift` for popovers and the player, `shadow-art` for fanned art and the email calendar.

MOTION

Move like a broadcast, not a slot machine. 150ms for hovers, 200ms for lifts and toggles, 500ms for slide changes, all on `cubic-bezier(.16, .8, .24, 1)`. The hero dwells 8s with a visible progress bar and a pause button. Ambient motion lives in three places only (the On Crooked drift, the Con sky, the credits roll) and pauses on hover or focus. Under `prefers-reduced-motion` all of it stops: the drift becomes a scroll row and the credits a static list. Motion has no tokens; these values are the rule.

IMAGERY, MARKS AND ICONS

- Each show's own 1:1 art, never recolored or cropped off-square. Fanned stacks rotate in 4° steps, five cards maximum. Host photography for live events, warm and candid.
- The "CROOKED" in this system is Big Shoulders set as a stand-in (`wm`: 34px, 900, tracking .02em). No official logo was supplied and none is drawn here. Production must use Crooked Media's wordmark files. Vote Save America and Friends of the Pod keep their own marks; don't rebuild them in type.
- The halo (a repeating radial ring in 13% yellow on navy) is the only decorative pattern. Collateral adds a small set of flat illustrative devices built from shapes: the sun disc, grass edge, record, calendar, checklist, scoreboard.
- Icons: the concept uses a single inline play triangle and the live dot. There is no icon set yet; when one is needed, use simple 2px-stroke glyphs in `currentColor` and add them under an Icons asset group. No emoji in brand voice; emoji appear only inside quoted chat bubbles.

TOKENS

`tokens.json` keeps the concept's three tiers and names. Primitives are `c-*`, semantic tokens are `bg-*`, `fg-*`, `border-*`, `accent-*`, `status-*`, `focus-ring` and `con-*`, and component tokens are `button-*`, `play-*`, `chip-*`. Components read semantic or component tokens, never primitives; collateral is the one exception, as above. Font families compile to `--font-display`, `--font-body` and `--font-mono`; `bundle.css` maps the concept's `--f-display`, `--f-body` and `--f-mono` to them so the concept's `index.html` keeps working.

Fixes this system makes to the concept:

- Red eyebrow text (3.9:1) now uses `status-live-text`.
- The 9px now-playing pill is 12px bold.
- Con type stays above the gradient midpoint.
- Preview and queue borders use `border-strong`, which flips to slate in dark mode.

- About 20 hard-coded hex values outside `:root` now have token names. In collateral, `#9AA3C0` became `c-slate-400`, `#33406B` became `c-navy-600` and `#262A35` became `c-chrome-800`.
- The "Early-bird ends Oct 6" line is past due; replace it with the current ticket tier or drop it.

VOICE AND TONE

Talk like the smartest friend in the group chat. Crooked is for people who follow politics closely, are tired of being scared by it, and want somewhere to put the energy. The voice treats them as smart, busy and already on the team. It explains, it jokes, and it always ends with something to do.

FOUR PILLARS

Action over anxiety. Name the problem in one beat, then turn to the move. Every piece leaves a door open: listen, show up, or organize.

> "The news, minus the panic." · "Down, not out." · "Doomscroll less. Doorknock more."

In on the joke. Self-aware and a little irreverent, especially about ourselves. The humor punches at the situation, never at the listener.

> "...and a few lowly podcast hosts." · "Hot takes. Yes. Twice a day, five days a week." · "Freedom & Content for All."

Plainspoken. Short words, real verbs, no insider fog. If a sentence needs a second read, it needs a rewrite. Concrete beats clever.

> "One email each weekday evening with what happened and what you can do about it."

Independent and proud of it. Membership keeps the network independent; it is never a donation plea. Confident, never pleading.

> "Your membership keeps Crooked independent and out of Big Tech's pocket." · "Ad-free. Fear-free."

TONE DIAL

Where the default voice sits on each axis (0 = left word, 100 = right word).

AXIS	SETTING	READS AS
Serious ↔ Funny	58	Slightly more funny than serious. The joke serves the point.
Casual ↔ Formal	35	Casual. Contractions always.
Urgent ↔ Calm	70	Calm. Urgency comes from a specific deadline, never from alarm.
Insider ↔ Welcoming	72	Welcoming. Explain the acronym; skip the inside baseball.
Opinionated ↔ Neutral	22	Opinionated. Say what we think and why.

FLEX BY SURFACE

SURFACE	DIAL TOWARD	EXAMPLE
Hero and section heads	Punchy, two beats, display caps	"Late-night politics. Live in LA."
Membership (Friends of the Pod)	Warm, value first, independence second	"Your favorite pods. Ad-free."
Organizing (Vote Save America)	Calm urgency, specific next step	"Find a shift, a donation match or a phone bank that fits your week."
Events (Crooked Con)	Most playful, spectacle, big stakes	"Freedom & Content for All"
Posters and socials	Two beats with a turn; the second beat is the action	"Ballot first. Brunch after." · "The polls close. We don't."
Stickers and merch	One line, wearable, gift-able, still true out of context	"Phone bank > fear bank" · "Hope is a verb"
Newsletter headers	A count plus a promise	"15 days. Every vote."
Product UI and microcopy	Quiet, literal, two or three words	"Up next" · "Saved" · "Hover a card to preview"
Commerce (Store)	Lightest touch	"A tee for the next protest or a gift for the Hysteria fan in your life."

WRITING RULES

Headlines. Two short beats split by a period, six words or fewer each. The second beat turns toward action. Write in sentence case; CSS sets the caps.

Buttons and links. Start with a verb: Play, Join, Find, Get, See, Shop. Say what happens: "Play today's lineup", not "Learn more". A pill CTA in collateral pairs the action with the program: "Find a shift · Vote Save America".

Body. One idea per sentence, under 25 words. Ledes stop at three sentences. Contractions always. Second person always.

Numbers and dates. Metadata uses abbreviated months, an en dash for ranges and a middle dot as separator: `Nov 5–7 · Washington, DC`. Never `11/5/26`. Counts in headlines are numerals: "15 days."

Errors and UI. Literal. "That didn't load. Try again." Save the jokes for editorial.

REWRITES

INSTEAD OF	WRITE	WHY
~~URGENT: Democracy is on the line. Donate now!~~	Down, not out. Find a phone bank that fits your week.	Action over anxiety. A specific ask beats an alarm.
~~Support our mission with a monthly contribution.~~	Your favorite pods. Ad-free.	Lead with what the member gets.
~~Click here to learn more about our podcasts.~~	Find your show	Verb first, no filler.
~~Stay informed with our daily newsletter.~~	The news, minus the panic	Promise a feeling, not a category.
~~Make sure you vote this November!~~	Democracy is a group project. Your part is due Nov 3.	Borrow a familiar format and give a deadline.
~~Oops! Something went wrong 😬~~	That didn't load. Try again.	UI copy stays literal.

HOUSE VOCABULARY

USE	AVOID	NOTE
Friends of the Pod; a Friend	subscriber, donor, supporter	Capital F when it means a member.
pods, shows, episodes	content, assets	"Content" only as the Crooked Con joke.
the network	the platform, the brand	Crooked is a network of shows, newsletters and events.
ad-free	premium, exclusive	Name the benefit literally.
Listen. Show up. Organize.	engage, activate	The three ways in. Keep the order.
Nov 5–7 · Washington, DC	11/5/26	En dash, middle dot, abbreviated month.

HOUSE LINES

Lines already written in this voice, cleared for reuse across pieces: Less doom. More doing. · Doom is not a strategy. · Down, not out. · The news, minus the panic. · Listen. Show up. Organize. · Hope is a verb. · Phone bank > fear bank. · Turn out, not off. · Ad-free. Fear-free. · Democracy is a group project. · Democracy is not a spectator sport. · Touch grass. Then protect it. · Ballot first. Brunch after. · Hot takes. Cool planet. · There is no planet B-side. · Everybody in. · Raise the floor. · Build it here.

WHAT THE VOICE NEVER DOES

- Fearmonger, all-caps-shout or count down to doom.
- Mock the listener, or anyone for being new to politics.
- Plead for money. Membership is value first.

- Put words in a real person's mouth. Quotes are real, attributed and checked.
- Use emoji in brand voice. Quoted chat voices may.

PUTTING IT INTO PRACTICE

How a brief becomes a piece. The live examples are the **Collateral** components: `Poster`, `SocialSquare`, `EmailBanner`, `StickerSheet`, `TeeGraphic`, `MerchLine`.

FROM BRIEF TO PIECE

1. **Name the action.** What should the reader do after seeing this: listen to a show, show up somewhere, or organize? Pick one.
2. **Write the two beats.** Beat one names the situation in the reader's words. Beat two turns it into the action. Six words or fewer each. Check it against the rewrites table.
3. **Choose a device.** Most pieces need none: the headline is the art. Add one device only if it carries the idea (see Devices below).
4. **Choose the ground.** Navy by default. Yellow for upbeat asks. Paper for policy claims in a box. Pink for reproductive freedom. Red for labor. Chrome for chat and app formats. Sky for climate only.
5. **Highlight one beat.** On navy, the turn goes yellow. On yellow, everything is navy. Never highlight both beats.
6. **Close with the CTA and the mark.** Pill CTA names the action and the program. Unofficial mark in the corner.

FORMATS

FORMAT	SIZE	COMPONENT	HEADLINE SIZE	NOTES
Poster / story	1200×1800	`Poster`	196–300px	90px padding, footer row with pill + mark.
Feed square	1080×1080	`SocialSquare`	178–220px	80px padding, eyebrow / headline / footer.
Newsletter header	1200×600	`EmailBanner`	118px	Headline left, one object right.
Sticker	320–360px die-cut	`StickerSheet`	44–66px	10px white kiss-cut border.
Garment print	1400×1400 artboard	`TeeGraphic`	150px	Two inks where possible.
Product mockup	square card	`MerchLine`	n/a	Flat silhouette on `c-slate-100`, spec caption.
Wide banner	1200×400 (3:1)	`EmailBanner` layout	96px	Used for the Everybody In series header.

DEVICES

Signature moves, each tied to a piece that uses it. One per piece.

- **Strike and swap.** Strike the doom word with a rotated red bar, then set the replacement in yellow. *Doomscroll less. Doorknock more.* · *Healthcare shouldn't have a ~~paywall~~.*
- **Borrowed format.** Dress the ask as something familiar: the homework checklist (*Democracy is a group project*), the group chat (*Your group chat, upgraded*), the weather forecast (*100% chance of turnout*), the scoreboard (*Home: Voters 26 · Away: Apathy 00*), the album tracklist (*Greatest Hits*: Social Security, the 40-hour week, Medicare, Voting Rights Act, Clean Air Act; bonus track: your vote), the record sleeve (*There is no planet B-side*), the sequel poster (*Democracy 2: The Sequel*), the certificate (*World's Most Persistent Phone Banker*), the national-park sign (*Visit your polling place*). The format carries the joke; the copy carries the action.
- **This or that.** Two panels, the left on white and the right on navy with the yellow answer. *Hot takes / Hot planet.*
- **The object.** One flat object holding the date or number: the calendar (*Nov 3*), the ticket, the checklist box.
- **The scene.** Flat shapes only: sun disc with two soft rings, a navy grass edge, mountains for the park badge. No photos, no people.
- **The seal.** Dashed yellow ring around a navy ring, mono line on top, display lockup inside. *Est. somewhere between doom and doing.*

MERCH RULES

- One line per product, drawn from the house lines.
- Ink from the brand palette; garment colors may extend it (black, forest, natural canvas, duck tan) and stay off screens.
- Series share one idea. *Everybody In*: Everybody in · Raise the floor · Everybody eats · Working people first · All of us · Build it here.
- Caption mockups as PRODUCT NAME over a mono spec line: "Planet B-side bucket hat · Navy twill · yellow embroidery".

BEFORE IT SHIPS

- [ ] Two beats, six words or fewer each, second beat is the action.
- [ ] One yellow highlight, one device, one CTA.
- [ ] Type above the sky midpoint; no butter or cream on `c-sky-300`.
- [ ] Red only as fill, or at display size; red text is `c-red-700`.
- [ ] Dates as `Nov 3` / `Nov 5–7 · Washington, DC`; nothing past due.
- [ ] The unofficial mark is present and legible.
- [ ] No real person quoted or pictured without a source; no official marks rebuilt in type.

MIDTERM MESSAGING

A campaign layer on top of the voice for the final stretch before the Nov 3, 2026 midterms. Same voice (action over anxiety, in on the joke), aimed at four targets. The live set is the **MidtermSet** component. These lines are dated: retire or rewrite them after Nov 3.

THE FOUR LANES

Every piece picks one lane, lands one joke, and ends with one action.

1. The cost of everything

The everyday bill: gas, groceries, rent, child care, tariffs. The joke is the gap between "prices are coming down" and the receipt.

- Gas is $4.20. Not a joke. *(Neither is Tuesday.)*
- Read the receipt. Then read the ballot.
- They called affordability a con job. Your receipt calls it Tuesday.
- "The party of affordability." Have you met a receipt?
- Your cart got smaller. Your ballot didn't.
- Fill the tank. Then fill in the bubble.
- Tax cuts at the top. Price hikes at the pump.

2. Check, please (the gold-plated White House)

The gold decor, the ballroom, the paved Rose Garden, and the Cheesecake Factory comparison that took over the week. The joke is the menu: lavish for them, nothing on it for you. Close the tab is the action.

- Check, please. *(Close the tab · Vote Nov 3)*
- Less Cheesecake Factory. More factories.
- Donors got a ballroom. You got the bill.
- Gold everything. Nothing on the menu for you.
- Affordability: 86'd.
- Your table's ready. Polls close at the end of the night.

3. For sale (the grift)

Self-dealing, donor favors, family business in the people's house. The joke is the swamp that got remodeled instead of drained.

- Drain the swamp? They put in a hot tub.
- Everything's for sale but your vote.

- Not a cabinet. A gift shop.
- The swamp got a renovation. You got the invoice.

4. Make it a short term (turnout)

The close. Every piece in the other three lanes can end here.

- Midterms Tuesday. Make it a short term.
- Four days. Every vote.
- Costume Saturday. Ballot Tuesday.
- The polls close. We don't.
- Democracy is a group project. Your part is due Nov 3.

RULES FOR THIS ROUND

- **Facts first, then the joke.** Every number is sourced and dated in the piece's notes: the $4.20 gas figure is the AAA national average for Oct 30, 2026. When a number moves, the line moves with it.
- **Quote only what was said.** "The party of affordability" and "con job" are the president's own words about affordability. Attribute or set them as quotes; never invent a quote or put words in a named person's mouth.
- **Punch at conduct, not people.** Mock the gold, the ballroom, the receipts, the self-dealing. No name-calling, no jokes about anyone's body, family or voters.
- **Grift, not crimes.** Say grift, self-dealing, for sale, donor's choice. Don't call anything a crime unless a charge or conviction says so.
- **The Cheesecake Factory is the punchline, not the target.** The chain and its diners are fine. The joke is the decor in the White House. No logos, no menu art, no trade dress.
- **Every piece ends with an action**: Vote Nov 3, make a plan, bring three friends, find a shift. Polling hours and rules vary by state; never print a single nationwide opening or closing time.
- Grounds follow the system: navy for cost of living, yellow for Check, please and turnout, red for who pays, chrome for grift, paper for receipts and other borrowed formats.

COLOR PRIMITIVES

c-navy-950
`#070F2A`
Dark-mode page ground (`bg-page` in dark).

c-navy-900
`#0A1A44`
The brand's ground: header, hero, footer, ink buttons, poster and social grounds. Text on paper, white and yellow.

c-navy-800
`#0F1C45`
Dark-mode surface (`bg-surface` in dark).

c-navy-700
`#14255A`
Dark-mode raised panels on navy.

c-navy-600
`#1C2F66`
Cards and panels sitting on navy (`bg-inverse-raised`).

c-navy-500
`#24356E`
Dark-mode hairline borders.

c-navy-400
`#2C4180`
Borders on navy; the inner ring on the tee graphic.

c-navy-300
`#3A4F8F`
Reserved step; no current use.

c-slate-600
`#56618A`
Muted text on paper and white (5.5:1 on paper).

c-slate-400
`#98A3C8`
Muted text in dark mode (6.6:1 on navy 800).

c-slate-300
`#AEB8DC`
Labels and eyebrows on navy (8.6:1); struck-out words in collateral at 55% opacity.

c-slate-200
`#D4DAF0`
Soft body text on navy: hero ledes, email-banner copy.

c-slate-150
`#D5DBEA`
Hairline borders on paper and white. Decorative only (1.4:1).

c-slate-100
`#EEF1F9`
Dark-mode default text.

c-slate-50
`#F2F4F9`
Paper: the blue-biased off-white page ground. Never pure white for the page.

c-yellow-500
`#FFD43B`
Signal yellow. The one thing to click or the thing happening now; display type on navy; poster and social grounds. Never text on white (1.4:1).

c-yellow-300
`#FFE278`
Hover state of yellow fills.

c-red-300
`#FF6B6B`
Live-red text in dark mode (6.8:1 on navy 950).

c-red-500
`#E5383B`
Live red. Fills only: live dot, now-playing pill, strike bars, calendar header, the Labor social ground. White on it is 4.2:1, so text on it is 12px bold minimum or display size.

c-red-700
`#B3261E`
Red text on paper, white and yellow (5.9:1 on paper, 4.6:1 on yellow): eyebrows, alerts, checklist time labels.

c-chrome-950
`#0D0F14`
Player and tool chrome; the group-chat social ground.

c-chrome-900
`#1A1D25`
Raised chrome: hover rows in the player and nav.

c-chrome-800
`#2A2E39`
Borders on chrome.

c-chrome-500
`#6B7080`
Disabled icons on chrome.

c-chrome-400
`#9A9FAD`
Muted text on chrome (7.2:1).

c-sky-700
`#1A5EF3`
Crooked Con only: top of the sky gradient.

c-sky-600
`#2C70F3`
Crooked Con only: mid sky; the 'Hope is a verb' sticker.

c-sky-500
`#2A6FF3`
Crooked Con only: alternate mid sky from the concept CSS.

c-sky-300
`#5C97F1`
Crooked Con only: bottom of the sky. No text here (cream 2.7:1).

c-sky-200
`#4C8DEB`
Crooked Con only: cloud shading.

c-cream-100
`#FFF5D6`
Crooked Con headline type; wordmark on red and sky collateral (4.9:1 on sky 700).

c-butter-300
`#F6EC8E`
Crooked Con display type, top two-thirds of the sky only (4.4:1 on sky 700, 3.7:1 on sky 600).

c-pink-300
`#F7B6D2`
Collateral ground for reproductive-freedom pieces and stickers, with navy type (10.1:1).

c-white
`#FFFFFF`
Surfaces on paper: cards, checklists, the lock box, the calendar.

SEMANTIC AND COMPONENT COLOR

TOKEN	LIGHT	DARK	USE
`bg-page`	#F2F4F9	#070F2A	Page ground. Text: `fg-default`, `fg-muted`.
`bg-surface`	#FFFFFF	#0F1C45	Cards, tables, panels on the page ground.
`bg-inverse`	#0A1A44	#0A1A44	Navy bands: header, hero, membership band, footer. Text: `fg-on-inverse` family.
`bg-inverse-raised`	#1C2F66	#14255A	Episode rows and panels inside a navy band.
`bg-chrome`	#0D0F14	#0D0F14	The player and sticky nav, so tools read apart from editorial.
`bg-chrome-raised`	#1A1D25	#1A1D25	Hovered rows and buttons on chrome.
`fg-default`	#0A1A44	#EEF1F9	Body and headings on `bg-page` and `bg-surface` (15.3:1 light, 16.7:1 dark).
`fg-muted`	#56618A	#98A3C8	Secondary text, table heads, eyebrows on `bg-page` and `bg-surface` (5.5:1 light, 6.6:1 dark).
`fg-on-inverse`	#F2F4F9	#F2F4F9	Text on `bg-inverse`.
`fg-on-inverse-muted`	#AEB8DC	#AEB8DC	Labels and metadata on `bg-inverse` (8.6:1).
`fg-on-inverse-soft`	#D4DAF0	#D4DAF0	Lede and body copy on `bg-inverse`.
`fg-on-chrome-muted`	#9A9FAD	#9A9FAD	Metadata on `bg-chrome` (7.2:1).
`fg-on-accent`	#0A1A44	#0A1A44	Labels on `accent-default` (11.8:1).
`border-default`	#D5DBEA	#24356E	Hairlines between rows and around cards. Decorative; never the only cue.
`border-inverse`	#2C4180	#2C4180	Hairlines on navy.
`border-chrome`	#2A2E39	#2A2E39	Hairlines on chrome.

TOKEN	LIGHT	DARK	USE
`border-strong`	#0A1A44	#AEB8DC	2px borders on floating UI: previews, queues, popovers, checklists (8.4:1 on navy 800 in dark).
`accent-default`	#FFD43B	#FFD43B	Signal: one primary action per view, play buttons, progress, selected-chip text.
`accent-hover`	#FFE278	#FFE278	Hover for `accent-default` fills.
`status-live`	#E5383B	#E5383B	Live fills: live pill, live dot. Not for text.
`status-live-text`	#B3261E	#FF6B6B	Red text on `bg-page` and `bg-surface` (5.9:1 light, 6.8:1 dark).
`focus-ring`	#FFD43B	#FFD43B	Keyboard focus. Yellow alone is 1.4:1 on white, so `bundle.css` pairs it with a 2px `fg-default` inner ring; together they clear 3:1 on every ground.
`con-sky-top`	#1A5EF3	#1A5EF3	Crooked Con band: gradient top. Headline zone.
`con-sky-mid`	#2C70F3	#2C70F3	Crooked Con band: gradient middle.
`con-sky-low`	#5C97F1	#5C97F1	Crooked Con band: gradient bottom. No type.
`con-headline`	#FFF5D6	#FFF5D6	Crooked Con headlines and eyebrows, upper sky only.
`con-display`	#F6EC8E	#F6EC8E	Crooked Con display words at 24px+, upper sky only.
`con-clock-bg`	#0A1A44	#0A1A44	Countdown tiles: navy hardware on the sky.
`con-clock-fg`	#FFD43B	#FFD43B	Countdown digits.
`con-rule`	#0A1A44	#0A1A44	3px rule closing the Con band.
`button-primary-bg`	#FFD43B	#FFD43B	Primary button fill.
`button-primary-fg`	#0A1A44	#0A1A44	Primary button label.
`button-primary-bg-hover`	#FFE278	#FFE278	Primary button hover.
`button-ink-bg`	#0A1A44	#0A1A44	Ink button fill, for yellow and sky grounds.

TOKEN	LIGHT	DARK	USE
`button-ink-fg`	#FFD43B	#FFD43B	Ink button label.
`play-bg`	#FFD43B	#FFD43B	Play button disc.
`play-fg`	#0A1A44	#0A1A44	Play button glyph.
`chip-selected-bg`	#0A1A44	#EEF1F9	Selected filter chip fill. Dark mode flips to slate so the chip still reads on navy surfaces.
`chip-selected-fg`	#FFD43B	#0A1A44	Selected filter chip label.

TYPE

display-xl · 112px/0.92 · 900

LESS DOOM. MORE DOING.

display-l · 64px/0.92 · 900

Find your show

display-m · 46px/0.92 · 900

Crooked Con is back

display-s · 28px/0.92 · 900

Tone dial

display-poster · 220px/0.86 · 900

Union made.

lede · 19px/1.55 · 400

Podcasts, newsletters and events for people who want a better conversation about politics.

title · 20px/1.25 · 700

Are Democrats saying the right things to win?

body · 16px/1.55 · 400

One email each weekday evening with what happened and what you can do about it.

body-s · 14px/1.5 · 400

Hover a card to preview

button · 15px/1.2 · 700

Play today's lineup

eyebrow · 12px/1 · 500

WHAT A DAY · 24 MIN · NOV 5–7

label-s · 11px/1 · 500

UNOFFICIAL CONCEPT

Spacing

`space-1`	`4px`	Icon-to-label gaps.
`space-2`	`8px`	Chip and button gaps; eyebrow to headline.
`space-3`	`12px`	Gaps inside rows: play button to title.
`space-4`	`16px`	Minimum side gutter; swatch grid gaps.
`space-5`	`20px`	Grid gaps between cards.
`space-6`	`24px`	Card and panel padding.
`space-7`	`28px`	Reserved.
`space-8`	`32px`	Space under a section head; Con band padding.
`space-10`	`40px`	Space above a sub-head.
`space-12`	`48px`	Large gaps inside hero bands.
`space-16`	`64px`	Section rhythm, top and bottom.

Radius

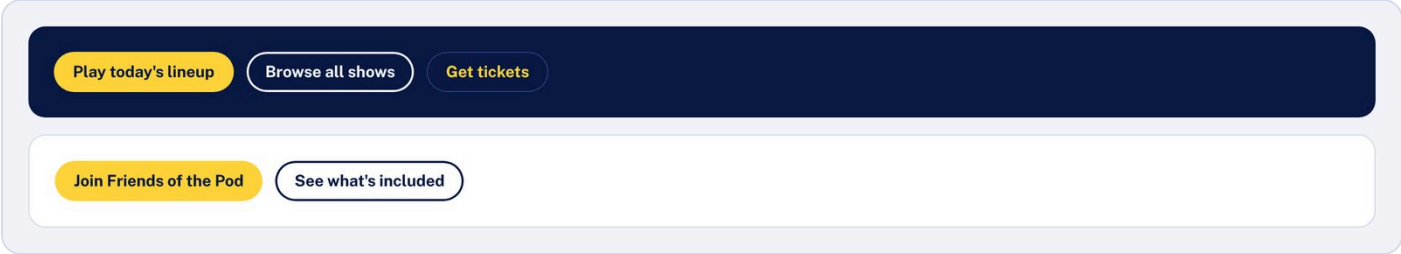
`radius-xs`	`4px`	Tiny tags.
`radius-sm`	`6px`	Code chips, contrast swatches.
`radius-md`	`10px`	Countdown tiles, notes.
`radius-lg`	`12px`	Show art and cards (`card-radius`).
`radius-xl`	`14px`	Lineup rows and the player.
`radius-2xl`	`16px`	Panels (`panel-radius`).
`radius-pill`	`999px`	Every button, chip, tag and live pill.

Shadow, sizes, layers

`shadow-card`	`0 18px 40px rgba(5, 10, 30, .35)`	Hovered show cards on navy.
`shadow-lift`	`0 24px 60px rgba(5, 10, 30, .5)`	Previews and queue popovers.

`shadow-art`	`0 18px 40px rgba(0, 0, 0, .4)`	Fanned show-art stacks; the email-banner calendar.
`layout-max`	`1240px`	Max content width.
`layout-gutter`	`clamp(16px, 4vw, 48px)`	Side gutter; always at least 16px.
`layout-nav-height`	`64px`	Sticky nav height.
`play-size`	`44px`	Play button; also the minimum touch target.
`play-size-compact`	`38px`	Play button inside the player bar.
`button-padding`	`10px 18px`	Button padding.
`f-size-display-xl`	`clamp(52px, 8vw, 112px)`	Hero headline.
`f-size-display-l`	`clamp(40px, 5vw, 64px)`	Section headline.
`f-size-display-m`	`clamp(34px, 3.6vw, 46px)`	Panel headline.
`f-lh-display`	`.92`	Display line height on screen. Collateral tightens to .86.
`f-track-label`	`.08em`	Mono metadata tracking.
`f-track-label-wide`	`.12em`	Countdown captions.
`z-header`	`20`	Sticky nav.
`z-dock`	`30`	Docked player.
`z-popover`	`40`	Hover previews.
`z-panel`	`41`	Queue panel.
`z-toast`	`50`	Toasts.

BUTTON



Pill buttons whose label is a verb phrase that says what happens.

Provide: an `<a>` or `<button>` with `ck-btn` plus one variant class, and a label that starts with a verb (Play, Join, Find, Get, See, Shop).

VARIANT	CLASS	USE
Primary	`ck-btn-primary`	Yellow (`button-primary-bg`) with navy label (`button-primary-fg` , 11.8:1). One per view, on navy or paper.
Ghost	`ck-btn-ghost`	Secondary action beside a primary. Inherits the text color of its band.
Ink	`ck-btn-ink`	Navy with a yellow label. Use on yellow and sky grounds where a yellow button would vanish.

- Do write "Play today's lineup", "Find a shift", "Get tickets".
- Don't write "Learn more", "Click here", or set the label in display caps.
- Don't put two primary buttons in one view. If three things are yellow, two are wrong.
- Radius is always `radius-pill` ; padding is `button-padding` ; label style is `button` .

CHIP

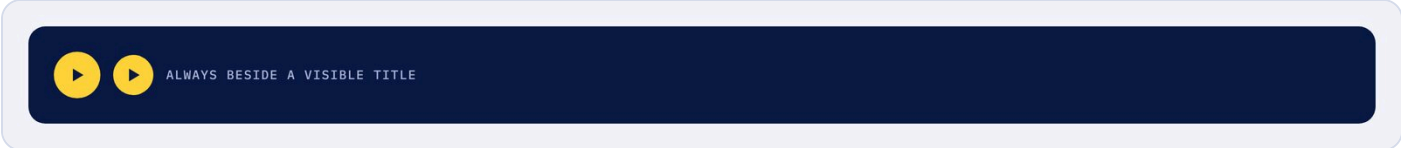


Pill filters for the show grid.

Provide: `<button class="ck-chip">` with `aria-pressed` set; the selected state is driven by `aria-pressed="true"`.

- Filter only. Never use a chip as a link or a tag that does nothing.
- Selected: `chip-selected-bg` with `chip-selected-fg` (navy and yellow in light; slate and navy in dark).
- Labels are short nouns in sentence case: "Daily news", "Law & courts".

PLAYBUTTON



The yellow disc that starts audio.

Provide: a `<button class="ck-play">` with an `aria-label` naming the episode, and a visible title next to it. Add `compact` inside the player bar.

- Size `play-size` (44px, also the minimum touch target); `play-size-compact` (38px) only inside the player, where the whole row is the target.
- Fill `play-bg`, glyph `play-fg`.
- Never a play button without a title beside it; never a second yellow action competing in the same row.

EYEBROW

WHAT A DAY · 24 MIN · NOV 5–7

FIND YOUR SHOW

Mono caps metadata above a headline.

Provide: `<span class="ck-eyebrow">` with facts only: show names, durations, dates, counts.

- Style `eyebrow`: IBM Plex Mono 500, 12px, tracking `f-track-label`, color `fg-muted` (or `fg-on-inverse-muted` on navy).
- Separate facts with a middle dot; ranges take an en dash: `Nov 5–7 · Washington, DC`.
- One eyebrow per block and only when it adds a fact. Never on every card by habit.

LIVEPILL



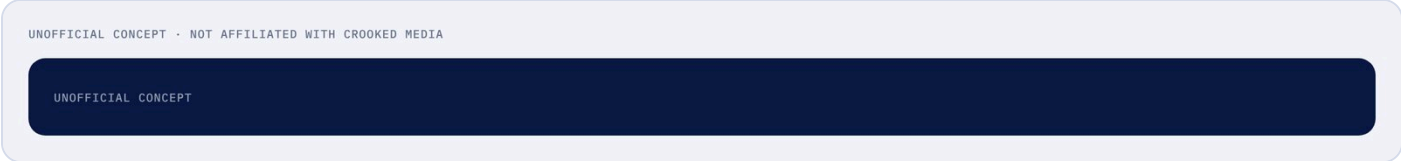
Red pill that marks audio or an event that is live right now.

Provide: `<span class="ck-live">` with a one-or two-word label; add `pulse` only while audio is actually live or playing.

- Fill `status-live`, white text at 12px bold minimum (4.2:1 qualifies as large-ish UI text only at that weight). The concept's 9px pill failed; don't go smaller.
- For red *text* (an eyebrow, an alert) use `status-live-text`, never `status-live`.
- Pulse stops under `prefers-reduced-motion`.

COMPONENTS · STATUS

UNOFFICIALMARK

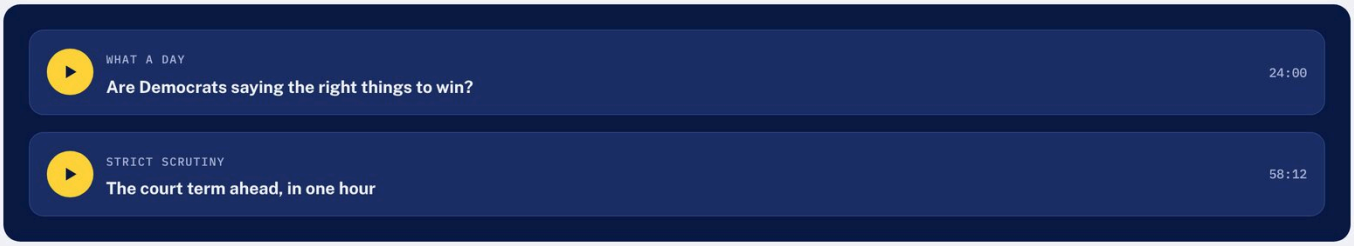


The line that keeps every piece honest about what it is.

Provide: `<span class="ck-unofficial">` placed in a corner or footer of every page, poster, social post, sticker sheet and merch mockup.

- Full form: "Unofficial concept · Not affiliated with Crooked Media". Short form on 1080^2 socials: "Unofficial concept".
- 11px Plex Mono at 55–60% opacity in the piece's own text color. Never removed, never hidden under art.
- The typeset "CROOKED" in Big Shoulders is a stand-in, not the official wordmark. Production work must use Crooked Media's own files and approval.

EPISODEROW

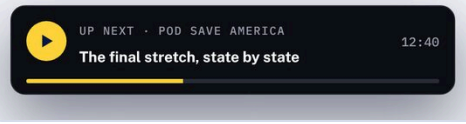


One episode in today's lineup: play, show, title, length.

Provide: show name (eyebrow), episode title (`title` style), duration in `mm:ss`, and a play button with an `aria-label`.

- Lives on `bg-inverse`; the row is `bg-inverse-raised` with `border-inverse`, radius `radius-xl`.
- Durations use tabular numerals in mono.
- Titles are the episode's real title, sentence case, no clickbait additions.

PLAYER



The persistent audio player.

Provide: current show, episode title, elapsed time and progress (0–100%).

- Chrome (`bg-chrome`), not navy, so it reads as a tool. Metadata `fg-on-chrome-muted`; progress fill `accent-default`.
- Floats bottom-left on desktop (`z-dock`, `shadow-lift`); docks full width under 700px.
- Microcopy stays literal: "Up next", "Saved", "Paused".

CONBAND



The Crooked Con sub-brand: daytime sky, cream and butter type, navy hardware.

Provide: dates and city (eyebrow), the event line, a countdown (days, hours, minutes), and one ink button.

- Gradient `con-sky-top` → `con-sky-mid` → `con-sky-low`, closed by a 3px `con-rule`.
- All type sits in the top two-thirds, or on navy hardware like the countdown (`con-clock-bg`, `con-clock-fg`). Butter or cream over `con-sky-low` fails (2.4–2.7:1).
- Buttons on sky are ink, never yellow.
- Sky colors never leave Con placements. Use the official event art for the eagle and clouds.
- Keep ticket copy current: the concept's "Early-bird ends Oct 6" line is past due.

EMAILBANNER



WHAT A DAY · COUNTDOWN HEADER

Newsletter header, 1200×600 (2:1), shown at 50%.

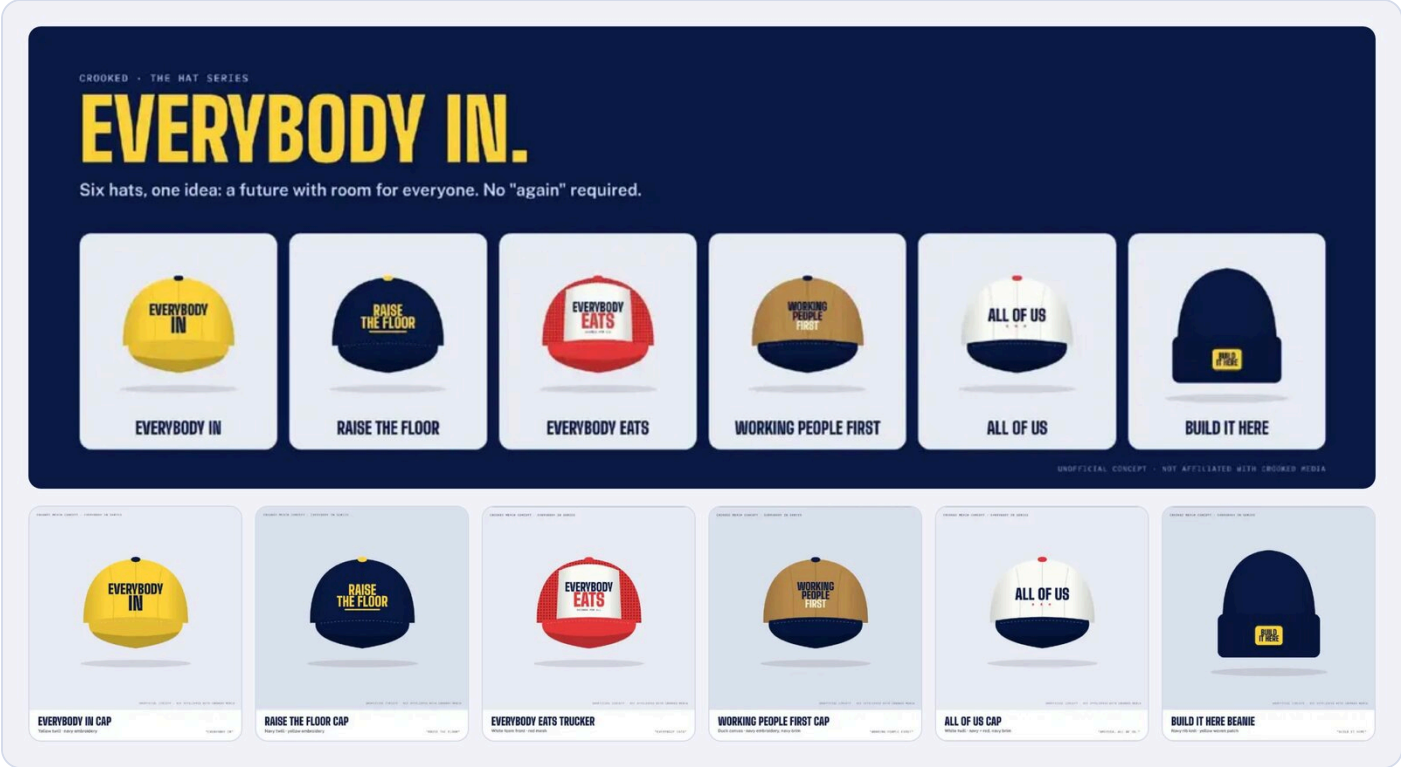
Provide: the newsletter name and moment as the eyebrow, a two-beat count headline in yellow, one sentence that promises exactly what's inside, and a single object on the right (calendar, ticket, receipt) that carries the date or number.

- Navy ground, halo pattern bottom-right, 70px padding, 1.3 : 1 split.
- The object is white with a red header strip and `shadow-art`; its number is display type.
- Body copy `c-slate-200` at 30px. Keep it to one sentence.

- Live text in the email body must repeat the headline; never put the only copy of a date inside an image.

- Count copy expires daily. As of Oct 30, 2026 the header reads "Four days. Every vote." Update or retire it after Nov 3.

HATSERIES

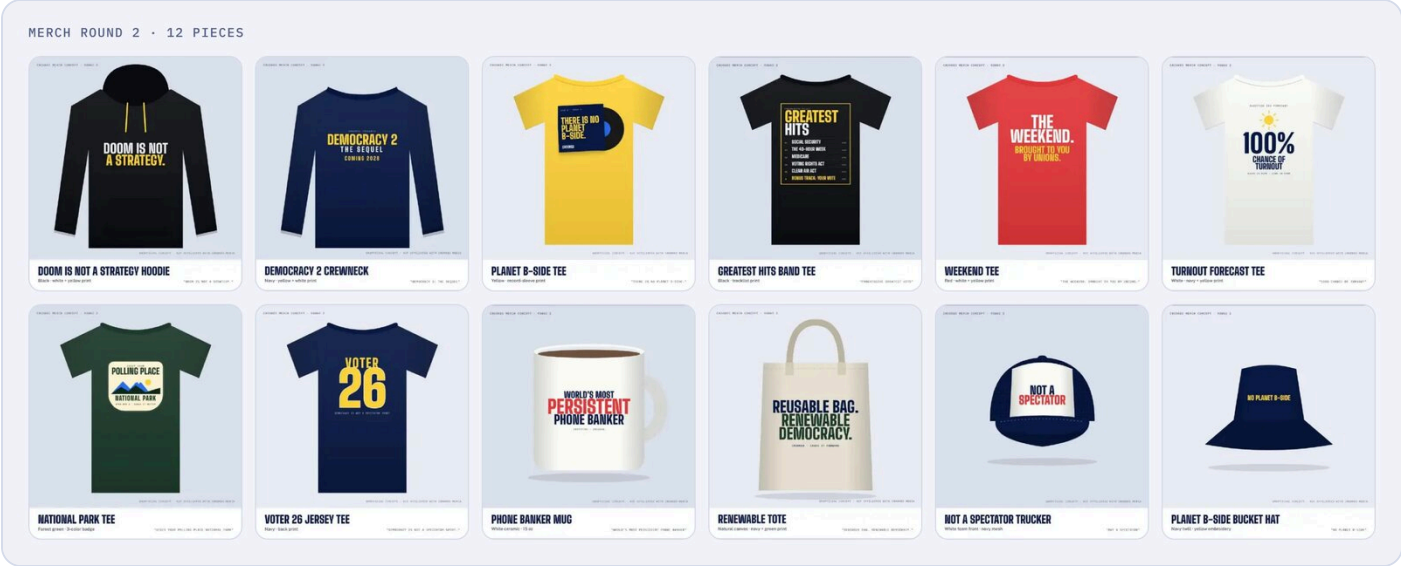


Everybody In: six hats, one idea, plus a 3:1 series banner.

Provide: one shared idea, one line per hat that restates it, a hat style per line (cap, trucker, beanie), and a twill or knit color with one embroidery or patch color.

- Lines: Everybody in · Raise the floor · Everybody eats · Working people first · All of us · Build it here.
- Banner: navy ground, yellow display headline, one row of hat tiles, one line of body ("Six hats, one idea…").
- Source images: asset group **Everybody In Hats**, rendered from the hats PDF.

MERCHLINE



How a slogan becomes product: garment color, ink, and one line. The preview shows the actual mockups from the merch PDFs from Merch Round 2; see also **MerchLookbook** and **HatSeries**.

Provide: the line (from the voice section), the garment and its color, the print method and ink colors, and a placement. Mockup cards caption as **PRODUCT NAME** in display caps over a mono spec line ("Navy twill · yellow embroidery").

- Inks come from the brand palette: yellow, navy, white, cream, red 700, red 500. Garment colors may go beyond it: black `#0E1015`, forest `#1F3B2A`, natural canvas `#E8E0CC`, duck tan `#B98A4E`. Those are product colors, not tokens; never use them on screen.
- One idea per product. Series share one idea across items ("Everybody In": in, floor, eats, working people, all of us, build it here).
- Borrowed formats carry the best pieces: the record sleeve (Planet B-side), the tracklist (Greatest Hits), the jersey number (Voter 26), the national-park badge, the certificate mug.
- Mockups are flat garment silhouettes on paper (`c-slate-100`) with the unofficial mark in the corner. No models, no photo comps of real people.

MERCHLOOKBOOK

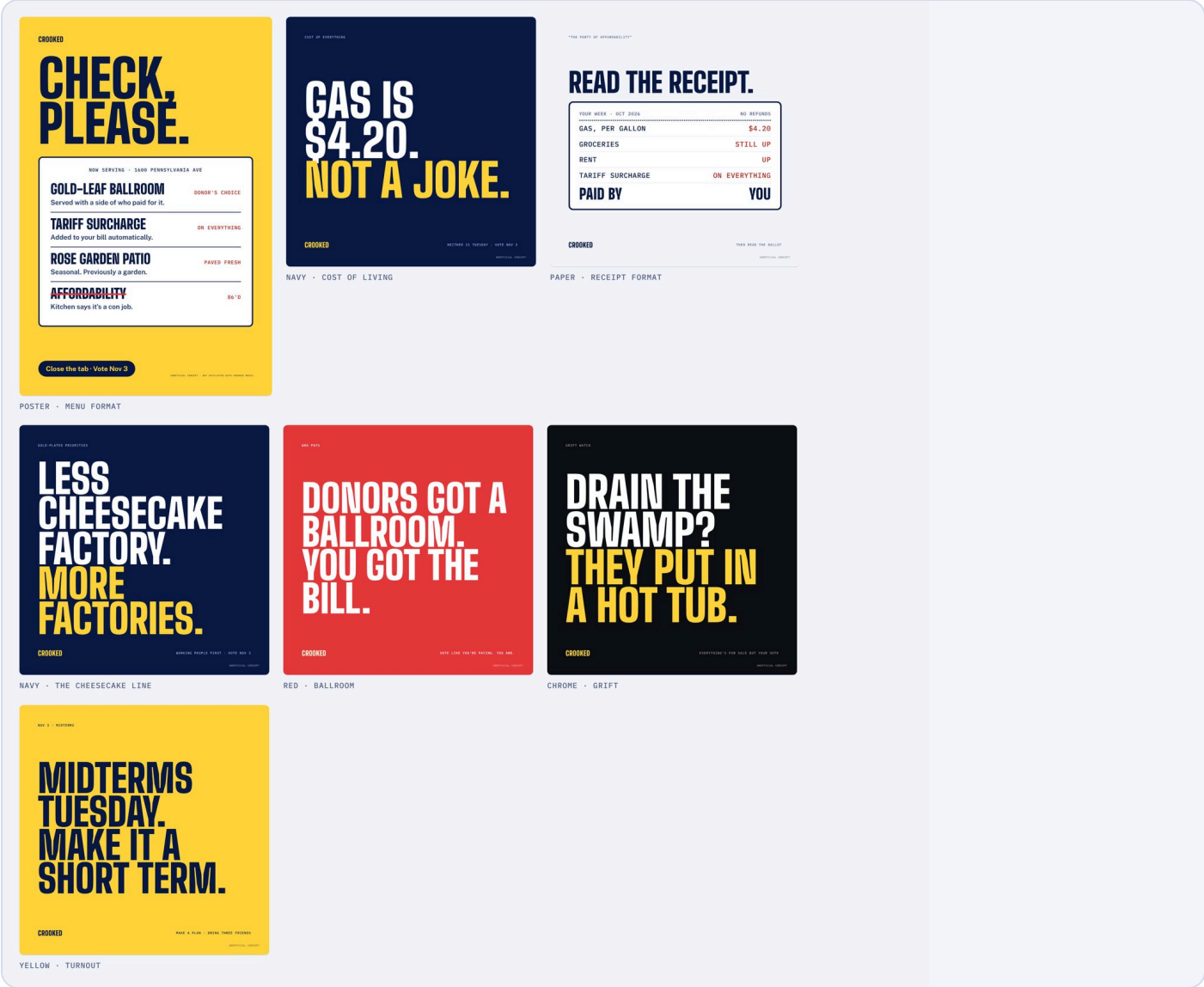


The merch lookbook: fourteen products, each carrying one house line.

Provide: a house line, a garment and color, the print method and inks, and a mockup caption (PRODUCT NAME over a mono spec line). The rules are in **MerchLine**.

- Lines used: Show up U.S. tour '26, Crooked says relax, Relax. Don't doom it. Do it., Listen. Show up. Organize., Doomscroll less. Doorknock more., Hope is a verb, Less doom. More doing., Touch grass. Then protect it., The news, minus the panic, Hot takes. Cool planet., Ballot first. Brunch after., Down, not out, Phone bank > fear bank, Turn out, not off.
- Source images: asset group **Merch Lookbook**, rendered from the lookbook PDF.

MIDTERMSET



The Nov 2026 midterm push: one menu poster and six feed squares across the four lanes in **Midterm messaging**.

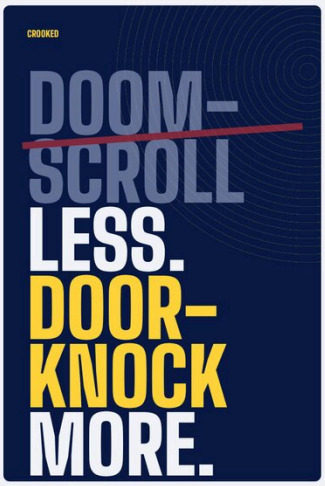
Provide: a lane, one line from that lane, a ground from the system, and a footer action that names Nov 3 or a concrete next step.

PIECE	LANE	GROUND	DEVICE
Check, please.	Gold-plated White House	Yellow	Restaurant menu: Gold-leaf ballroom (donor's choice), Tariff surcharge (on everything), Rose Garden patio (paved fresh), Affordability (86'd)
Gas is $4.20. Not a joke.	Cost of everything	Navy	None; the number is the art

PIECE	LANE	GROUND	DEVICE
Read the receipt.	Cost of everything	Paper	Receipt: gas, groceries, rent, tariff surcharge, paid by you
Less Cheesecake Factory. More factories.	Gold-plated White House	Navy	None
Donors got a ballroom. You got the bill.	Gold-plated White House	Red	Display only
Drain the swamp? They put in a hot tub.	Grift	Chrome	None
Midterms Tuesday. Make it a short term.	Turnout	Yellow	None

- The menu and receipt devices are white boxes with a 6px `c-navy-900` rule and 20px radius; line items in Plex Mono caps, prices in `c-red-700`; the 86'd item is struck with a `c-red-500` bar.
- The gas figure is the AAA national average for Oct 30, 2026. Update it or swap the line if the average moves.
- Dated set: retire after Nov 3.

POSTER



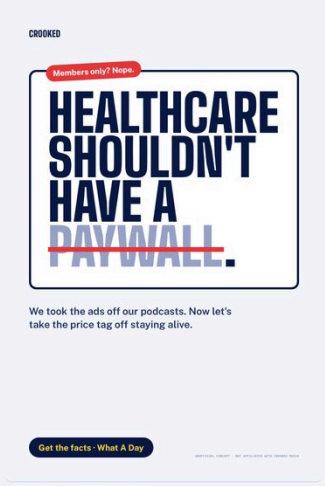
NAVY · STRIKE-AND-SWAP



YELLOW · BORROWED FORMAT



SKY · SCENE



PAPER · BOXED CLAIM

Print and story-format poster, 1200×1800 (2:3), shown here at 25%.

Provide: a two-beat headline (six words or fewer per beat), one sentence of body that names a specific action, one pill CTA naming the program, and the unofficial mark.

Anatomy, top to bottom: wordmark stand-in (`wm`, 34px) → headline (`display-poster`, 196–300px, leading .86) → optional device (checklist, lock box, scene) → `sub` (40px Public Sans 600, max 20em) → footer row with pill CTA left and unofficial mark right, padding 90px.

Four grounds, one per piece:

GROUND	HEADLINE	USE
Navy `c-navy-900`	paper text, yellow for the turn	The default. Halo pattern top-right.
Yellow `c-yellow-500`	navy	Upbeat asks; ink pill or none.
Sky gradient	cream, then butter	Climate and outdoors only; the one non-Con use of sky, kept to the upper half, with navy ground at the foot for body copy.
Paper `c-slate-50`	navy in a white lock box	Policy claims; red tag for the hook.

- The strike-and-swap device (struck word in `c-slate-300` at 55% with a rotated `c-red-500` bar, then the replacement in yellow) is the system's signature move. One per piece.
- Yellow is the turn of the sentence, not decoration. Highlight one beat.
- Grounds are fixed brand colors; posters don't follow the viewer's theme.

POSTERROUND2



Round 2 posters: each one dresses the ask as a familiar format, so the format carries the joke and the copy carries the action.

Provide: the format (diagram, record sleeve, tracklist, calendar, certificate, forecast, sequel poster, park sign, scoreboard), a headline in two beats, one line of body that names the action, and a pill CTA naming the program.

POSTER	BORROWED FORMAT	GROUND
Doom is not a strategy	Game-plan diagram (Plan A: Doom, struck)	Navy
There is no planet B-side	Record sleeve	Yellow
Greatest Hits	Album tracklist with a bonus track	Chrome
The Weekend. Brought to you by unions.	Week calendar	Red

POSTER	BORROWED FORMAT	GROUND
World's Most Persistent Phone Banker	Certificate of achievement	Cream
100% chance of turnout	Weather forecast	Sky
Democracy 2: The Sequel	Movie poster	Navy gradient
Visit your polling place	National-park sign	Cream + forest
Democracy is not a spectator sport	Scoreboard (Voters 26, Apathy 00)	Navy
Reusable bag. Renewable democracy.	8:1 web banner	Paper

- Source images: asset group **Round 2 Posters**, rendered from the Round 2 PDF.
- Cream and forest green are format colors for the certificate and park sign only, not tokens.
- Every poster keeps the unofficial mark in the footer.

SOCIALSQUARE



Feed post, 1080×1080, shown here at 38%.

Provide: a topic eyebrow (top-left), a headline of two or three beats, a footer with the wordmark stand-in left and one mono line right that names the show or the action, and "Unofficial concept" bottom-right.

- Padding 80px; layout is eyebrow / headline / footer with `space-between`.
- Headline `display-poster` at 178–220px. Fit by size, never by squeezing tracking.
- Grounds: navy (default), yellow, chrome (for chat and app formats), pink (reproductive freedom), paper (comparisons), red (labor and display-only pieces; white or cream type at display size only, since white on red is 4.2:1).
- Footer mono line credits the show that covers the topic (Pod Save America, Strict Scrutiny, What A Day) or restates the system line.
- In chat-format posts, the friend's yellow bubble carries the turn toward action; lowercase and emoji belong to the quoted voices only.

STICKERSHEET



EIGHT DIE-CUTS, 10PX WHITE KISS-CUT BORDER

Die-cut stickers: one slogan each, display type only.

Provide: a slogan of two to six words; a shape (circle 320, burst 340, rounded rect 340×200 at 24px radius, oval 360×230); a ground and ink pair from the list below.

GROUND	INK	RATIO
`c-yellow-500`	`c-navy-900`	11.8:1
`c-navy-900`	`c-yellow-500`	11.8:1
`c-pink-300`	`c-navy-900`	10.1:1
`c-chrome-950`	`c-yellow-500`	13.5:1
`c-white` + 6px navy rule	`c-navy-900`	16.9:1
`c-red-500`	`c-white`	4.2:1, display size only
`c-sky-600`	`c-cream-100`	4.1:1, display size only (the one sky use outside Con)

- 10px white kiss-cut border on every shape.
- Bursts carry the loudest lines ("Down, not out", "Less doom. More doing.").

- Slogans come from the house lines in the voice section; no new jokes on stickers without a second read.

TEEGRAPHIC



ORGANIZER TEE · CENTER CHEST

Print-ready garment art on a 1400×1400 artboard, shown at 30%.

Provide: a seal line in mono (the joke), the display lockup (the claim), and a mono credit line ("Crooked · Department of …").

- The seal: a dashed `c-yellow-500` ring (r 430, 2/22 dash, 60%) around a solid `c-navy-400` ring (r 360).
- Display at 150px in yellow; mono lines 22px, tracking .1em.
- Two-color screen print where possible (yellow + white on navy). Garment color carries the ground.

MERCH ROUND 2



DEMOCRACY 2 CREWNECK
Navy · yellow + white print



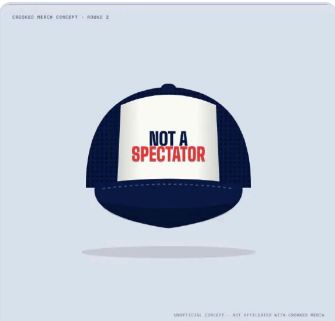
DOOM IS NOT A STRATEGY HOODIE
Black · white + yellow print



GREATEST HITS BAND TEE
Black · tracklist print



NATIONAL PARK TEE
Forest green · 3-color badge



NOT A SPECTATOR TRUCKER
White foam front · navy mesh



PHONE BANKER MUG
White ceramic · 15 oz



PLANET B-SIDE BUCKET HAT
Navy twill · yellow embroidery



PLANET B-SIDE TEE
Yellow · record-sleeve print



RENEWABLE TOTE
Natural canvas · navy + green print



TURNOUT FORECAST TEE
White · navy + yellow print



VOTER 26 JERSEY TEE
Navy · back print



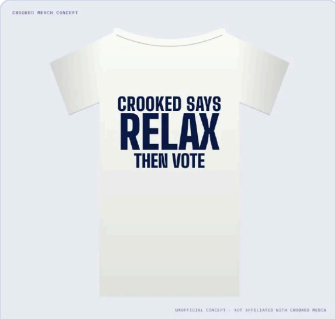
WEEKEND TEE
Red · white + yellow print

CONCEPT COLLATERAL

MERCH LOOKBOOK



BALLOT BRUNCH MUG
Yellow ceramic · 15 oz



CROOKED SAYS RELAX TEE
White · navy block print



DON'T DOOM IT TEE
Navy · yellow + white block print



DOORKNOCK TEE
Yellow · navy + red print



DOWN, NOT OUT DAD CAP
Navy twill · yellow embroidery



HOPE IS A VERB TEE
White · left-chest print



HOT TAKES MUG
Navy ceramic · 15 oz



LESS DOOM HOODIE
Navy · yellow print, sleeve hit



MINUS THE PANIC MUG
White ceramic · 15 oz



ORGANIZER TEE
Navy · yellow + white print



PHONE BANK CAP
Stone twill · navy embroidery, navy brim



SHOW UP U.S. TOUR '26 TEE
Black · front + back print



TOUCH GRASS HOODIE
Black · full-color sky panel



TURN OUT BEANIE
Yellow rib knit · navy woven patch

EVERYBODY IN HATS



ALL OF US CAP
White twill · navy + red, navy brim



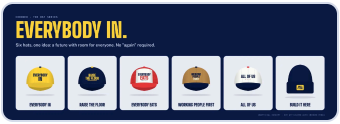
BUILD IT HERE BEANIE
Navy rib knit · yellow woven patch

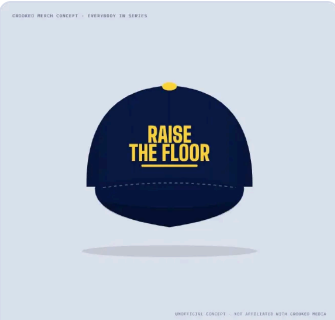


EVERYBODY EATS TRUCKER
White foam front · red mesh



EVERYBODY IN CAP
Yellow twill · navy embroidery



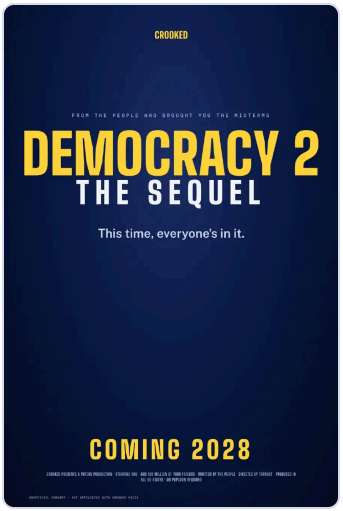


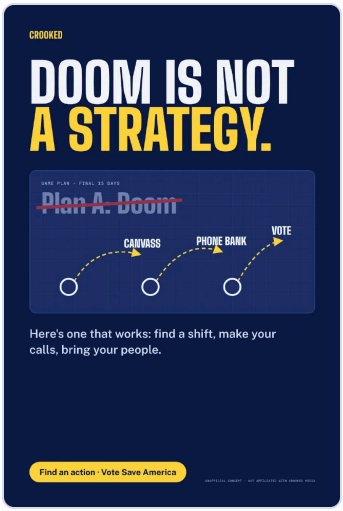
RAISE THE FLOOR CAP
Navy twill · yellow embroidery



WORKING PEOPLE FIRST CAP
Duck canvas · navy embroidery, navy brim

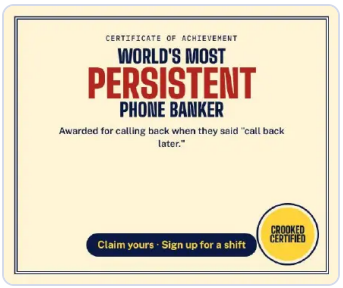
ROUND 2 POSTERS









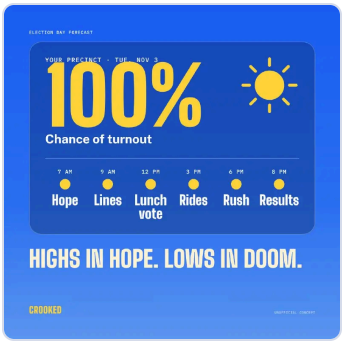












CROOKED

Crooked homepage concept · Brand and design system reference book · Oct 30, 2026.

Unofficial concept. Not affiliated with Crooked Media.